The Heights of Winter Rogaine for 2015 returned to the Blythe Valley after the 2014 event was cancelled due to torrential rain leading up to the event. The rain we had leading up to 2014 event turned out to be the last rain experience in the valley until a week before the 2015 event. While this is a dire situation for the farmers, it did result in a dry fast course for rogaining. While 80 percent of the course was as planned for the 2014 event, we had an extra coastal strip south of Napenape, and lost access to a farm on the western edge to the course. In many ways this was an improvement to the overall balance of the course. We ended up with a course with a central hash house and many different terrain types. One of the satisfactions of planning a course is to watch the field head off in many directions at the start.

The weather on the day was perfect resulting in the majority of teams staying out for the full event. Of course this also means a real rush of teams arriving together. The Navlight system performed fantastically well, and generally there was a minimal wait for team results. We were able to have the finalised results printed 30 minutes after the finish of the event. There was only one faulty control (51) which while not recording the time, did record points (except for 3 teams where it failed to record the points). The controls were placed over Queens Birthday Weekend so after 4 weeks in the field, this is testament to the durability of the Navlight system.

The overall winner of the 12hr event was the team of Chris Forne and Greg Hamilton, who once again demonstrated their dominance in the NZ Rogaining scene. The winner of the MV grade, Matt Bixley and Martin Lukes showed that age is no handicap by coming in 2nd, and they were closely followed by Tane Cambridge and the young and upcoming Nick Hann. The WO team of Georgia Whitla and Lara Prince were also dominate in their grade, and achieved an overall placing of 4th. This is fantastic result when you consider the quality of the competition. One other performance of note is the winning XJ team of Alastair McDowell and Selena Metherell who were 9th overall. With such a high quality field the challenge for the planners is to create a course that cannot be cleared, and that all competitors have to make choices about which controls to miss out. This was achieved this year with the winners leaving over 500 points out on the field.

The race in the 6hr event was between the MO team of Steven McKinstry, Nick Ross and Dene Gavin and the XV team of Carsten Joergensen and Jenni Adams, with the MO team coming out on top. The MJ team of Conner Cleary and Stephen Harding were not far behind to take 3rd overall. It is interesting to note that there were a total of 60 women's teams compared to 21 men's teams, and the phrase "Spring Challenge" was definitely in the air.

The "oddest" moment of the day was a phone call from Team 8. They had found a 3 legged dog near control 77, and were going to carry it to the water drop near control 20. We duly sent someone to the water drop to collect the dog. In the meantime Stephen Field (Blythe Downs) was phoning around trying to find the owner. The dog was bought back to the hash house where he hopped around until picked up by its owner.

There was a small but dedicated team of volunteers that put together this year's HOW. Of special note is Grant Hunter who is the "behind the scenes" man organising all the necessary

tasks that are only noticed if something goes wrong. Anne Hunter assisted in number of tasks including providing her expertise on the registration desk. Pete Squires provided help over the weekend both setting up the event site, retrieving controls after the event and assisting the novice Navlight user. Chris, Abby and Lara Dixon assisted in the setting of the course over Queens Birthday, and Abby and Lara helped with general duties on event day and collecting controls. Emma de Lacey handled all the entries, Trevor Merrifield the finances and Bill Kennedy produced the results for the website. Colin Dixon and I had the pleasure of planning the course which over the last two years has given us an intimate knowledge of the Blythe valley.

The assistance of Stephen Field from Blythe Downs was essential for the smooth running of the event. He is a proud farmer who wanted to make the rogaine a memorable event for the competitors. His wife Phoebe kept us supplied with morning and afternoon tea.

As an organising team I am happy that we provided an event worthy of the Heights of Winter. Rogaining events only happen due to a dedicated team of rogainers who are prepared to give up the opportunity to compete so that the sport we all love can continue to grow and thrive. If you are a rogainer at some stage you need to put up your hand to help in the running of an event.

If you have any comments (good or bad) regarding the running to the HOW 2015 please email me, as we want to make sure future events build on the success of previous events and learn from any mistakes that we may have made.

For another review of the event from a competitor's point of view try Mat Bixleys blog at https://runlongergeek.wordpress.com/.

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